

CATAN — Rules Reference

An original, concise reference to the rules and mechanics of the base game of CATAN (for 3–4 players). Written for quick lookup and question answering.

Goal of the game

The first player to reach 10 victory points on their own turn immediately wins the game.

Victory points come from settlements, cities, the Longest Road and Largest Army special cards, and Victory Point development cards.

Components and terrain

The board is made of 19 terrain hexes surrounded by sea. Five terrain types each produce one resource: forest produces lumber, hills produce brick, mountains produce ore, fields produce grain, and pasture produces wool. The desert hex produces nothing and is where the robber starts. Each non-desert hex has a circular number token from 2 to 12 (there is no 7 token). Players share a supply of resource cards, a deck of development cards, and each player has 5 settlements, 4 cities, and 15 roads in their colour.

Setup

At the start, each player places 2 settlements and 2 roads on the board. Settlements are placed on corners (intersections) and roads on edges. For the second settlement, each player takes one resource card for each terrain hex touching that settlement. This is the only starting resource you receive.

Turn structure

A turn has three steps in order. First, the active player rolls the two dice; the sum determines resource production. Second, the player may trade. Third, the player may build. You may also play one development card at any point during your turn.

Resource production (the dice roll)

After the roll, every hex showing the rolled number produces its resource. Each player who has a settlement touching that hex receives 1 resource card of that type; each city touching that hex receives 2 resource cards. This applies to every player, not just the active one. If the robber is on a hex, that hex produces nothing this turn.

Rolling a 7 and the robber

If the dice total is 7, no resources are produced. Instead: every player holding more than 7 resource cards must discard half of them, rounded down. Then the active player moves the

robber to any other terrain hex and steals 1 random resource card from a player who has a settlement or city touching that hex. The robber blocks its hex from producing resources until it is moved again.

Building costs

Road costs 1 lumber and 1 brick. Settlement costs 1 lumber, 1 brick, 1 wool, and 1 grain. City costs 3 ore and 2 grain, and upgrades one of your existing settlements (you get the settlement piece back). A development card costs 1 ore, 1 wool, and 1 grain.

Building rules

Roads must connect to one of your own roads, settlements, or cities. A new settlement must be built on an empty corner that follows the distance rule: it must be at least two edges away from any other settlement or city (no two settlements may be adjacent). A settlement must also connect to at least one of your own roads. A city can only be built by upgrading one of your own existing settlements.

Victory points

Each settlement is worth 1 victory point. Each city is worth 2 victory points. The Longest Road card is worth 2 victory points. The Largest Army card is worth 2 victory points. Each Victory Point development card is worth 1 point. You need 10 points to win.

Longest Road

The first player to build a continuous road of at least 5 segments receives the Longest Road card, worth 2 victory points. If another player later builds a strictly longer continuous road, they take the card. If a tie or a break drops the holder below the lead, the card can change hands or be set aside.

Largest Army

Each time you play a Knight development card you place it face up in front of you. The first player to have played 3 Knight cards receives the Largest Army card, worth 2 victory points. It is taken by any player who later has played more Knights than the current holder.

Trading

On your turn you may make domestic trades: offering resource cards to other players in exchange for other resource cards. Players may only trade with the active player, not with each other. You may also make maritime trades with the bank: 4 identical resources for 1 resource of your choice (4:1). If you have a settlement or city on a generic harbour you may trade 3:1. If you are on a specific resource harbour (for example a brick harbour) you may

trade 2 of that resource for 1 of any resource (2:1).

Development cards

Development cards are bought from a shuffled deck for 1 ore, 1 wool, and 1 grain. There are three kinds. Knight cards (the most common) let you move the robber and steal, and count toward the Largest Army. Progress cards come in three types: Road Building lets you place 2 free roads, Year of Plenty lets you take any 2 resources from the bank, and Monopoly lets you name one resource type and collect every card of that type from all other players. Victory Point cards are each worth 1 point and are kept hidden until you can use them to reach 10. You may play only one development card per turn, and you may not play a card the same turn you bought it — except Victory Point cards, which can be revealed at any time to win.

The dice and probabilities

Two six-sided dice are rolled, so totals range from 2 to 12. The number 7 is the most likely roll and triggers the robber. Among production numbers, 6 and 8 are the most likely (printed in red), while 2 and 12 are the least likely. Number tokens are placed so that high-probability numbers are usually spread out.

Common questions

You win the instant you reach 10 points on your turn, even mid-action. You cannot build a settlement adjacent to another settlement because of the distance rule. A city replaces a settlement and produces double resources. You only receive starting resources from your second placed settlement. The robber stays on its hex, blocking production, until a 7 is rolled or a Knight is played to move it.